



THERE IS A BUG IN MY LAPTOP



Scan to review worksheet

Expemo code:

1CQV-42EB-QPJ9



1

Warm up

In pairs, discuss the following questions.

1. How much do you know about computers? Do you consider yourself an expert?
2. Are you able to fix your computer if it breaks?
3. When do you decide that a computer is unfixable?
4. How often do you buy a new computer? Why do you decide to buy a new one?





2

Video introduction- What is a software bug?

Focus on keywords. Before watching the video match the underlined words to the definitions below.

1. The area behind the school is out-of-bounds, the kids aren't allowed there. (idiom)
2. The forest was incredibly dense as far too many trees had been planted during previous years. (adj.)
3. I always struggled with numbers, and it was arithmetic that I found particularly difficult. (n)
4. I heard they had to classify the information so the newspapers couldn't get a hold of it. (v)
5. I really like the interface of my new tablet; it is so easy to use. (n)
6. One of the root causes of obesity is the consumption of drinks with a high percentage of sugar. (n)
 - a. the way a computer presents and receives information from the user
 - b. the primary reasons for the existence of a problem
 - c. the type of maths that deals with adding, subtracting, multiplying etc.
 - d. containing a lot of things closely together with very little space between each one
 - e. officially make something a secret
 - f. a place where nobody or nothing is allowed to go

3

Prediction and listening comprehension

Ask your partner the following question, then watch the video to see if you were correct:

What is a software bug?



Watch the video one more time and try to answer the following questions.

1. What is a bug?

2. Which people do bug bounty programs employ?

3. What are the five most common types of bug?

4. How can they address the problem of bugs?

5. How can a bug be debugged?



4

Focus on vocabulary

Let's look at some vocabulary that will help your understanding of the article.

Part A: Match the following vocabulary to the definitions.

- | | |
|--------------------------------|---|
| 1. <u>nomophobia</u> (n) | a. be well respected and admired |
| 2. <u>doomscrolling</u> (n) | b. making loud usually deep noises to display feelings of dissatisfaction or annoyance. |
| 3. <u>acting up</u> (phr. v) | c. caused/ started by something else |
| 4. <u>groans</u> (v) | d. behave badly |
| 5. <u>malfunction</u> (v) | e. a personal story that is usually funny or interesting |
| 6. <u>esteemed</u> (adj.) | f. continue to look through items of bad news on social media even if they promote feelings of depression and sadness |
| 7. <u>anecdote</u> (n) | g. a psychological condition in which people have a fear of becoming detached from their mobile phone |
| 8. <u>sprung from</u> (phr. v) | h. not work as intended |

Part B: Put the vocabulary from Part A into the correct gaps in the following sentences. You may need to change the form of the word.

1. I had to delete Twitter because my _____ was out of control and I was starting to feel down.
2. He told me an _____ about a time he lost his keys in the toilet, it was hilarious.
3. My phone began to _____ quite badly, so I took it to the repair shop to get fixed.
4. He had become an _____ professor loved by his students and his peers alike.
5. Whenever I leave my dog home by herself, she really starts _____. Last week she ripped a massive hole in the sofa.
6. The idea I had for picking up litter _____ a documentary I watched about the environment.
7. _____ is a modern thing, and I am not sure if I have it, but I don't like to be without my phone.
8. Whenever he finds out that he has to do overtime at the office he lets out two or three really loud _____.



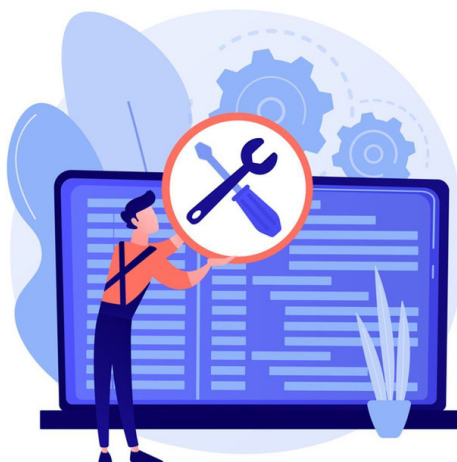
Now with your partner, discuss the following questions.

1. Do you ever doomscroll? Do you think that it is a bad habit?
2. Can you tell an interesting anecdote about something that happened to you recently?
3. What do you think about the concept of nomophobia? Do you think that it is a real thing?

5**Skimming for general understanding**

Read the following paragraph titles for the article on page five. Match them to the correct paragraph. One is not needed.

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ New words for new tech | ☐ Word of mouth |
| ☐ The real insect inside the machine | ☐ Thomas and his pet moth |
| ☐ Important Mark | ☐ Dig a little deeper for the truth |
| ☐ Dictionary corner | ☐ Phone bugs |





Excuse me? There's a bug in my laptop

How a real-life insect influenced the world of computers

A. _____

Advances in technology often bring an increased requirement for more language. Being able to discuss new programmes and gadgets quickly and efficiently is an important process if we want to stay up to date and relevant. This progression in language can often be tracked by any new words that the Oxford Dictionary adds each year. For example, in 2019 they added E-bike, in 2020 there was crypto-currency and nomophobia and in 2021 doomscrolling was entered into the dictionary. With some of these new terms it is abundantly clear how the word originated, but with others the story is a little more intriguing and that has never been truer than the word bug, as in computer bug.

B. _____

The story took place somewhere between 1945 and 1947 when a team at Harvard University were working on a computer called Mark II. Mark II was an Aiken relay calculator being tested for the US Navy and was considered crucial work in those post war years.

C. _____

So, when the Mark II started acting up, groans of dissatisfaction from the researchers could be heard echoing around the famous university's labs. The computer had been delivering consistent errors and so the team decided to open up the hardware to see where the root of the problem lay. To their surprise they discovered an actual bug inside, a moth had become trapped inside the machine and was contributing to a malfunction in the electronics. The team logged the unusual event in their records with the caption: "first actual case of a bug being found" and that is when the term bug was born, or is it?

D. _____

Some historians have suggested that the term bug existed a long, long time before the story of the moth at Harvard came to light. In a supplement to the 4th edition of the Oxford Dictionary there is a description of a bug as being "a defect or fault in a machine, plan or the like".

E. _____

There is even evidence the word had been used even earlier, in 1878 and by the esteemed Thomas Edison no less. In a time when he was soon to begin work on the lightbulb and the motion picture camera Edison was working on improving the efficiency of another new invention, the telephone. In a letter dated, March 3rd 1878 and addressed to William Orton the president of Western Union, Edison describes a problem he is having, "You were partly correct, I did find a "bug" in my apparatus, but it was not in the telephone proper".

F. _____

After this Edison started using the term as part of his everyday vocabulary and even developed it to include expressions like a machine requiring a "bug trap" to work properly. As he was such an influential figure it is likely that the term then spread out throughout his network and his peers and subordinates may have started using the term freely and creatively as well.

G. _____

The story of the moth in the computer at Harvard is a wonderful anecdote and it'll probably be one that is handed down as truth from generation to generation due to its memorable and surprising nature. However, with many unusual words it is often worth doing a little more digging to discover where these wonderful items of vocabulary sprung from.

Sources: *Inlingua Malta, BBC, TimeOut, Atlas Obscura, JSTOR Daily, National Geographic, IFL Science*



6

Reading comprehension

Read the following statements and decide if they are true (T), false (F) or not given (NG).

1. It's impossible to see the evolution of language through a dictionary. _____
2. The scientists at Harvard were working on something for the military. _____
3. The Mark II had continual problems. _____
4. The team found a component that resembled a moth. _____
5. The moth was saved, and you can now see it in a museum. _____
6. Historians think that the term bug existed a lengthy period before the Harvard incident. _____
7. The term bug may have been used by Eddison's friends, colleagues, and employees. _____
8. The story of the bug in the computer at Harvard is likely to die out soon. _____

7

Talking point

In pairs discuss the following questions.

1. What do you think is the most surprising thing in the article?
2. How would you feel if you found an actual insect inside your computer?
3. Have you heard any other stories about animals damaging machines?
4. Are you surprised that the term bug has such an interesting history?
5. Do you think many people know about the Harvard story? How about the story with Thomas Eddison?